

Close reading and annotation | Passage: The Keeper of the Point

The Keeper of the Point

Author: Original passage

The old lighthouse had not shown its light for thirty years, but the town still set its clocks by it. Every evening at dusk, Mrs Hollis would walk to the point and stand where the beam once swept the water. She said she was watching for ships; everyone knew she was watching for her son.

He had left on a fishing boat the spring the light went dark, and the sea had kept him. And/or so the story went, nobody in the town was quite sure, and nobody asked. The lighthouse and the woman kept their vigil together, two landmarks the tide could not move.

This is an original prose extract written for annotation practice.

Tasks

1. Identify one example of symbolism and explain its effect.

Focus quote: "the town still set its clocks by it"

2. How does the writer use the lighthouse to reflect the woman's grief?

3. Comment on the effect of the phrase 'two landmarks the tide could not move'.

Focus quote: "two landmarks the tide could not move"

Answer Guide - Tutor Copy

Task	Suggested Response	Marking Criteria
Task 1	The lighthouse symbolises constancy and memory; the town setting clocks by it shows how grief becomes routine.	Identifies symbolism Explains effect on meaning
Task 2	The dark, unused lighthouse mirrors the mother's suspended life, still standing, still watching, but without its former purpose.	Links image to character Uses textual evidence
Task 3	The metaphor equates the woman and the lighthouse, presenting her grief as permanent and immovable.	Analyses metaphor Evaluates effect on reader